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Freedom from an Inescapable Prison of Society

Society steers people toward a life of traditions and norms, which limits the pursuit of freedom. Over the course of centuries, trailblazers have resisted these traditions, successfully chipping away at institutional norms and securing freedoms for their representative minorities. In the novel, *The Awakening*, the author Kate Chopin shares the despairing, but inspirational story of a repressed woman, living in a society where she is essentially property of her husband; the protagonist, Edna Pontellier, progressively challenges the cultural norms that oppress her. The middle aged-woman is stuck in a forced marriage with Leonce Pontellier. Leonce embraces a stereotypical relationship of the 1890s, as he takes control of the power, deems Edna as property, and limits her ability to think and act independently. Unlike most women, Edna lives a dual life: inwardly questioning and outwardly conforming to these traditional expectations. She discovers a hint of freedom when she is on vacation with another man, Robert Lebrun, and experiences equal control. The newfound freedom is liberating and intoxicating. Edna subsequently dedicates time with her friend Adele and Reisz to explore this awakening. Robert ultimately concludes that for the better of Edna, he must leave her, as he wants a traditional marriage and life. In response, Edna drowns herself, as she cannot find a way to live her dream of being herself. Chopin uses motifs to argue that it is more paramount to endeavor in breaking free from constraints of tradition than to live a life of conformity, even though independence and freedom are unattainable for women in the milieu of the 1890s.

Chopin metaphorically introduces Edna as a bird, caged by the traditional society; while Edna seemingly successfully raises her wings and escapes, she ultimately breaks her wings because independence is unattainable in this era. As Edna tastes freedom, she develops the confidence to try and break free from the cage. Edna spends more time with Reize, who advises, “the bird that would soar above the level plain of tradition and prejudice must have strong wings... Whither would you soar?” (Chopin 69). Edna heeds to this advice, boldly rejecting social constraints, for example, by investing in relationships with other men, and leaving her husband to establish her own residence. Edna tastes freedom, and she would not go back to her imprisoned life as a piece of property of another man, trapped in a traditional society. Ultimately, however, Robert breaks her heart. As a result, Edna commits suicide. Next to Edna, there was “a bird with a broken wing was beating the air above, reeling, fluttering, circling disabled down, down to the water” (Chopin 95). Edna is a bird giving up to society, knowing that freedom is unattainable. Chopin compares birds to Edna, and she prefers death to a return to a caged life.

Throughout the novel, Chopin employs the motif of a dream to represent a society that has not awakened. Edna sleeps and dreams next to Robert on a day trip. When Edna wakes up, Robert explains to her that “you have slept precisely one hundred years... They thought it best not to awake you. Any way, I wouldn’t have let them” (Chopin 32). A sleeping society is a traditional one, and societies enjoy their traditions. Firstly, had Edna had actually slept one hundred years, she would have emerged into a new world in the 1990s where her freedoms would be fostered and cherished. Thus concluding that Edna is not meant for the time period they are in. Secondly, although she pines for Robert, and they share a mutual love, Robert still embraces a traditional society. Hence, he will not allow for her to be awakened; he prefers her in the sleeping society, similar to other women who have conformed to society, such as Edna’s

friend Adele, “the fair lady of our dreams” (Chopin 8). Adele represents women embracing traditional roles that lack freedom, constrained in a dream and unawakened to change. Unlike Adele, Edna desires for the freedom of independence that is not available in this society.

Finally, Chopin uses the ocean as a motif to represent freedom. To Edna, “the voice of the sea is seductive... inviting the soul to wander for a spell in abysses of solitude; to lose itself in mazes of inward contemplation... The voice of the sea speaks to the soul” (Chopin 6). Edna is free when swimming in the ocean. In fact, she leaves her wedding ring behind, freeing herself from the demeaning prison of her marriage. She has no choice but to eventually return to shore and return to her husband, who is not interested in her swimming. He only cares that she fulfills traditional female roles, such as childcare and cooking. Additionally, after Edna receives a breakup note she walks into the ocean and “she thought of the terror that seized her at the fear of being unable to regain shore. She did not look back now, but went on and on” (Chopin 95). Edna finally concludes that she cannot escape her caged society; her freedom is doomed. She boldly exercises her only remaining choice: the freedom to end her life. She chooses to do so in the ocean, where she feels comfortable, away from the shores of a relic society that had not quite lost its terrible grip on women’s rights.

Through her use of motifs, Chopin argues that breaking free from societal conventions is more crucial than conforming, even though women in the 1890s cannot fully attain true independence and freedom. In this society, if Edna tries to break free and leave Leonce, she will be institutionalized in a mental hospital. Therefore, her suicide is the only option, almost as a source of strength, to resist society in the only remaining way possible. Throughout the novel, Edna is awakened with her dream of reality and decides that she would rather spend the rest of her life, dead or alive, in an independent ocean, rather than be caged within an insufferable and

prejudice society. As time passes, society slowly adjusts and new norms are recreated. Within every era, there is a set of developed traditions, which may seem to limit the pursuit of freedom for some people. However, there are more psychologists and therapists in society to help people follow their dreams and to show them their potential paths in life, without having to result to suicide.